



Definition (SD) format continued to be available to customers, and a few niche services were added to HD and placed in a different price tier. The same model will be applicable to our market. According to a senior spokesperson at DishTV, customers who wish to continue with their present STBs and programme packages and do not want to subscribe to special HD content—which can be movies or sports—will continue to receive it at the price that prevails, and HD will be available to those who wish to subscribe. The impetus for HDTV will come from Prasar Bharati's plans to roll out HDTV content for the Commonwealth Games in 2010.

According to DG2L Technologies, a STB manufacturer, you can, in the future, expect STBs supporting both HD compression standards. These will also have external USB connectivity support and will support up to three tuners for video stream playback. They will also support the ancillary triple-play services—VoD, VoIP, and videoconferencing.

Other Services

Apart from HDTV, companies are looking at other forms of content delivery platforms too. IPTV and Mobile TV are the future contenders for the delivery of HDTVs in India.

Along with Aksh Optifibre Ltd., MTNL offers IPTV in Delhi and Mumbai for as little as Rs 300 a month. IPTV uses optic fibre networks; this ensures faster transfer rates and therefore a better viewing experience. In spite of the prices being so attractive, the only problem is that optic fibre networks are not available everywhere. The deal between Reliance ADAG and



The services that will be offered five years down the line will be more user-specific. DVRs will be common in every household, thereby eliminating prime-time broadcasting to a large extent"

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Microsoft to provide IPTV to its customers is important, because Reliance ADAG has last-mile fibre-optic connectivity in all major cities and towns in India. Combined with DTH offerings, these will ultimately reduce the end-user's dependency on the smaller cable operators, while the larger ones move towards digital delivery with better picture quality.

Currently, what hinders IPTV is that there are no regulations in place with regards to the content, and nor are there any guidelines for the delivery of media content over fibre networks. Once these are finalised by the Government—which will happen by next year, when the TRAI enacts a draft modification it proposed to the existing Cable Television Networks (Regulation) Act—the commercial launch of IPTV will be possible.

Another emerging form of media convergence is Mobile TV; according to Juniper Research, India and China will account for 36 per cent of global Mobile TV users by 2011. At 232.87 million mobile phone users (July 2007 TRAI figures) and a nation crazed by Bollywood and cricket, this means a real lot of money for the telecom companies. Mobile TV uses the either of two forms of technologies, Digital Video Broadcasting—Handhelds (DVB-H) or 3G. DVB-H is a technology that is embedded into the mobile phone that allows it to receive terrestrial broadcasts while 3G refers to third generation mobile phone networks capable of offering high-speed Internet access and multimedia communications at minimum transmission rates of 144 Kbps.

There is, however, a glitch—DVB-H based Mobile TV uses terrestrial broadcasting technology, the rights of which are only available with Doordarshan, this makes it impossible for other networks to beam their content in India right now. 3G services, on the other hand are not yet ready in India.

To view Mobile TV, the end user also has to have a DVB-H or 3G-compatible handset—something only available on the very latest mobile phones. Mobile TV will therefore take some time to go mainstream—unless mobile carriers like Vodafone and Airtel bundle different tariff plans with DVB-H or 3G compatible handsets based on agreements with video content producers, and if the Government makes terrestrial broadcasting free for everyone.

In Parting

The HD tale in India reads like a chicken-and-egg story. While the range of available HDTVs is increasing every day, most consumers are putting off the purchase for later citing the lack of HD content on their telly. On the other hand, the production houses and other content producers are delaying the production of HD content citing the lack of HDTV owners in India. From a Juniper Research report in November 2007, titled "Mobile TV: Executing the vision"—and from what we've gathered—HD will at least take another three years to arrive in India. ■

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Jargon Buster

Direct To Home: (DTH) Satellite broadcast transmissions aimed directly at individual households, to be received with a small dish.

Blu-Ray: A high-density optical disc format used to store mostly high-definition video.

HD-DVD: A competing format to Blu-Ray.

HD-VMD: Another competing format that uses red laser technology as opposed to blue laser technology used by the former two.

VoIP: Voice over Internet Protocol is the technology used to route voice conversations over a computer network. This provides significant cost benefits when used instead of traditional phone line services.

Video on Demand (VoD): A service that allows users to watch video over a computer network. The user can choose to both stream the content in real-time or download and watch it later.

Interactive TV: Allows users to choose and watch premium content like new movies, or change view angles in a cricket match, or play games on a TV.

NTSC and PAL (also called SD): The leading colour-encoding systems used in broadcast television systems around the world. India uses PAL.

MPEG-2: A compression standard; it is used to distribute movies and other media on DVD and similar discs.

MPEG-4 AV: MPEG-4 AV incorporates many of the MPEG-1 and MPEG-2 features while adding support for new ones such as better 3D rendering and support for externally-specified Digital Rights Management. This is a developing standard.

IPTV: A service where digital television is delivered over computer networks, ideally those that support broadband speeds. Contrast with DTH services.

DVB-H: Digital Video Broadcasting—Handhelds is the technical specification used to transfer digital media content to handheld devices.